This is done by the concept of *Māyā,* or the principle of nescience. The existence of *Avidyā* in ourselves cannot be denied. As *Avidyā* dissolves and true *Vidyā,* or the knowledge of the *Brahman,* dawns, the *Brahman* is more and more revealed. On complete realization of true knowledge, nothing remains but the *Brahman.* Not only is the world and the plurality of the Selves destroyed, but along with it *Avidyā* also disappears. *Māyā* also is both real and unreal, that is, it is practically real but ultimately unreal. That is why it is called *Anirvacanīya,* or indescribable. This admission of the principle of *Māyā* in *Advaita Vedānta* has evoked persistent objections from non-*Advaitic* systems, but the *Advaitists* have never regarded it as a vulnerable point in their metaphysics.

Advaita, however, is not subjectivism, for according to *Advaita* epistemology, all knowledge points to an object beyond it. Even error has an objective counterpart. The appearance of the snake in the rope is not real, but it is not wholly unreal either, or else it could not appear at all. Error is thus the apprehension of that which is neither being nor non-being, hence, it is inexpressible *Anirvacanīya.* Ultimate truth is not only coherent but also all-comprehensive. "All this, verily, is *Brahman" (sarvam khalvidam brahma).* Man's ultimate aim is to know that he himself is *Brahman.* The ego is a blend of the Self and the non-Self. Any objectification of the Self is *Avidyā,* or the individual's share of *Māyā.* To know oneself as *Brahman* and as completely dissociated from the non-Self is true knowledge and man's complete emancipation.

VEDĀNTA-THEISTIC

As if by a natural rebound against the absolutism of Śankara, the theistic tendencies of *Śaivism* and *Vaiśnavism* tried to reassert themselves, and in the *Viśiṣtādvaita* of Rāmānuja (A.D. 1100) we find a powerful attempt to synthesize *Vaiśnavism* with *Vedānta.* The effort is embodied in Rāmānuja's commentaries on the *Vedānta-Sūtra* and the *Gītā.*

The world and the soul, says Rāmānuja, are to the *Brahman* what the body is to the soul. Neither can exist nor be conceived without Him *(Aprathak-siddhi).* In the *Upaniṣads,* it is contended that all the three are distinct and eternal, though of unequal status and inseparably associated. The one *Brahman,* however, informs and sustains both Matter and Soul: hence monism *(Advaita).* The embodied is one: the embodying, many: hence qualified monism *(Viśiṣtādvaita).*

In theistic *Advaita, Prakṛiti, Jīva,* and God are conceived as important substances. Out of *Prakṛiti,* whose nature and evolution is conceived largely in the *Sāmkhya-Yoga* fashion, the world evolves